



The security slot will keep your laptop where you last left it

is connected to a steel rod within the chassis; trying to take apart the rod is as good as breaking the laptop. The slot can be identified by a little lock icon, with the letter 'K' on it.

Hardware security devices available in India range from the simple, to the sophisticated. At the bottom of the list are ordinary devices that lock into the security slot and have a tough steel cable to wind around a table leg or some permanent hook-like fixture. This prevents a crook from just picking up your laptop and walking away with it. We looked at a mechanical device, that has a combination lock and

comes with a 1.5m length of tough steel cable around it. Setting it up is simple: attach the device into the security slot, wind the cable around a table leg (or use the supplied steel hook that can be mounted on a wall) and lock it. This device works great if you tend to be less mobile. Short of sawing through the thick steel cable, the table leg, or trying to break the code on the combination lock, you can't steal a laptop with this device protecting it.

There are more sophisticated devices available that work with inbuilt motion sensors. We found that Targus's DefCon 1 systems (www.targus.com) allow you to set sensitivity levels on a motion sensing equipped device; one particular model, the PA 400, lets you connect a clip-like device into the security lock, loop a steel cable through it and lock it into the motion sensing device. Shake the laptop or the motion sensing device, and an ear-splitting alarm sounds. You can only turn it off by unlocking the three-digit combination lock and undoing the cable. This should be enough to grab the attention of everyone who isn't already deaf and also give the potential thief a good scare. An even more sophisticated DefCon 1 product, the PA 430B, comes with a motion sensing device, cables, a clip and also has a remote control that lets you trigger the alarm by proximity as well as motion detection. Move the tiny remote controller beyond 12m from the laptop and the alarm goes off. You can also trigger the alarm by pressing on a button in the remote controller. This device is ideal for travelers who can secure their laptops whilst travelling in high-risk public areas such as airports. Both these security devices will not allow you to access the battery compartment until you unlock the device, so somebody intent on stealing your laptop cannot disable the alarm. Keep in mind that while these devices are relatively secure, there is still nothing like total security; at best they provide a deterrent to stealing your laptop.

Secure the insides

It's possible that despite all your best efforts, you might still lose your laptop. If you are insured, there will be negligible financial loss, but what about the data sitting on your hard drive? Corporate espionage is a growing problem; the confidential data on your machine may of immense value to the competition. Even e-mail and ordinary correspondence can be a source of information. Your only shield here is making sure

that the computer cannot be accessed by anyone but yourself, and that the data is still unreadable should someone try to swap drives—BIOS and Windows passwords are not adequate security. Use a relatively more secure OS such as Windows 2000 or Windows XP that does not allow users to log in without valid user accounts, and patch the OS with the latest service packs. Then use commercial tools to further secure and limit access. To this end, we worked with two tools, both of which offer substantial boot-time security and real-time drive encryption features. The tools used here are Eracom's ProtectDrive and SafeBoot Solo—they can also be used to secure your desktops.

To run these tools, you need to have a Windows-based laptop with a little hard drive space and blank formatted floppy diskettes. You will be prompted to create rescue diskettes at installation, which can be used to recover from hard drive failure, or from a corrupted setup. These are administrator diskettes and that they can be used to log in to your machine, so store them safely.

SafeBoot Solo

SafeBoot Solo (www.safeboot.com) is simple, easy to use and is shareware—after the trial period expires, SafeBoot will delay boot-up by a minute. It allows for simple configuration and is a very easy-to-use tool.

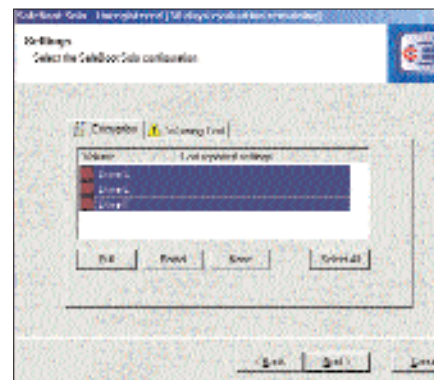
Installation: Installing SafeBoot is a two-step process—installation and configuration. Double-click on the setup file to start the installation. Once installed, you are prompted to reboot, after which a simple configuration process starts. First up, you will be prompted to enter a username and password, which you will use to authenticate, as well as change SafeBoot's settings. Now you can opt to encrypt all or some of your drives—either partial or complete encryption. A partially encrypted



The Targus DefCon 1 PA 400 motion sensing device secures your laptop



The plain and effective mechanical lock and chain that keep your laptop in place



Encrypting drives using SafeBoot